Zaheer had taken six wickets in the match and had again shown his importance as the leader of the attack. It was an amazing victory, one of our best away wins.

Before the final Test, I met up with Anjali and the kids and my friends Vivek and Sonia Palkar in Cape Town on 30 December and we celebrated the Durban win and the penultimate day of 2010 at a fantastic vineyard, the Constantia Uitsig. The place also had a cricket field and an excellent restaurant. It was an experience I was looking forward to, having consciously tried to learn more about red wine after visiting Australia in 1999. The celebrations continued on 31 December, when the team ushered in the New Year at a fabulous hotel in the foothills of Table Mountain.

In the third and deciding Test match at Cape Town on 2 January 2011, South Africa batted first on a pitch that offered reasonable help for the seam bowlers throughout the match. The ball was doing a lot off the pitch and in the air and batting wasn't easy. It was apparent to us all that South African captain Graeme Smith was not at all comfortable against Zaheer's left-arm swing. This was evident to us when he played a ball to midwicket and just jogged a single when he could easily have picked up two runs. I remember Bhajji running beside the ball and urging Smith to go for a second run. His refusal to do so suggested he had lost the mental battle to Zaheer, and we used the opportunity to give him a hard time in the middle. Kallis played brilliantly again, however, and, thanks to his 161, South Africa posted a competitive 362 in their first innings.

I went in to bat towards the end of day two and played a handful of deliveries to settle in. Then I came forward to a ball from Dale Steyn pitched on middle-and-leg and played it to midwicket for four. Everything about that shot – the swing and flow, my body position and foot movement – felt perfect and something told me I was in for a good innings.

The next day I resumed on 49, knowing the morning was going to be tough. Gautam Gambhir and I were up against two of the finest bowlers in the world in Dale Steyn and Morne Morkel – and in helpful bowling conditions. In an attempt to counter the movement, I deliberately stood outside the crease. My thinking was that if I was beaten from there, the ball would most likely go over the stumps. To get bowled I would have to miss an overpitched delivery, which was unlikely, and if the South Africans decided to dig in short I could play the upper cut over the slips.